

An Easter Meditation by Greg Saracoff

As Spring comes upon us, we again try to visualize the struggles Christ faced as death drew near:

- the struggle to do His Father's will, though He knew it would kill Him.
- His search for human support and the weakness of his closest friends (Peter and John) who didn't pray, but slept.
- His dogged determination to keep heading toward the cross.

What an example of love and obedience! Yet with this example clearly before us, we find ourselves day-dreaming, distracted. The writer of the Hebrews had to stop his sermon to deal with his distracted audience (Heb 5:11). Can we find the diligence to obey or are we doomed to another season of distraction? Christ, even though He was already God, was obedient to the Father. Can our love for the Father move us into expressing our passion for Him?

Hebrews 12:1-2 reminds us to "throw off everything that hinders and the sin that so easily entangles, and run with perseverance the race set out for us. Let us fix our eyes on Jesus...who for the joy set before Him endured the cross...."



Gardens and Stuff by Kathy



... "What I'm trying to do is to get you to relax, to not be so preoccupied with *getting*, so you can respond to *God's giving*..." (Mt 6:33 The Message)

It seems like this last year I've been hauling a lot of stuff across the border—bread, truckloads of food, household supplies, clothes and toys and Christmas boxes, etc. Some of it is desperately needed and some probably ends up in the trash. Lately the rules at the border have changed. The Mexican government has new restrictions on what

can be brought into Mexico—most food, clothing, shoes and toys are now prohibited. You know, this could be a very good thing. Our goal isn't to clutter people's lives with stuff or create dependency, but to help them respond to God's giving.

We want to concentrate on what we CAN bring—God's good news and skills to empower people to live healthy useful lives. Growing gardens, for example. We're introducing people to the Square Foot Garden model using the space they have available. We emphasize recycling water, amending soil by composting, and growing sprouts for those with limited space. Because it's so hard to get stuff across, we're in need of funding to establish gardens and buy supplies in Mexico.

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What we believe is this: If we get included in Christ's sin-conquering death, we also get included in His life-saving resurrection.

Romans 6:8 *The Message*



THE LATEST FROM EL REFUGIO: FIRE UPDATE

Pastor Chuy moved the "abuelos" back into El Refugio Dec 23, approximately 6 weeks after the fire. While the fire was a devastating event many churches, individuals and community groups on both sides of the border stepped in to assist in the demolition and rebuilding of the damaged rooms. El Refugio now has new wiring and an alarm system. A bonus is the new tile flooring in the courtyard area.

Esperanza Rehab helped with temporary housing and their daily operations. Esperanza's young women housed and helped care for some of the elderly displaced women. Most of the rest of the elderly were cared for and housed by Pastor Javier Marquez' church and men's rehab. The publicity sparked many donations of food, clothing and supplies. We hope the supportive relationships will flourish and continue, since the goal is to upgrade the care available for the elderly. An example of this is nursing students from UC San Marcos who have come each quarter to help out.

We welcome a new addition to Team Tijuana, Elias Cortes, who will serve as administrator for El Refugio and the Micro Finance loans. The challenge for Elias will be to keep the number of elderly within fire marshal requirements. Another challenge is to find stipends for the volunteer staff at El Refugio—25 folks needed to give \$25/month.



TEAM TIJUANA UPDATES

New Faces: Megan Riggott, new full-time LAM missionary from Minnesota, brings nursing skills which she puts to work at El Refugio as well as at Carretas. megan-in-mexico.blogspot.com is her blog. Rosa Sanchez, wife of Martin, the first grad from the old-time rehab in 1989, is now assisting in the Tuesday ministry to Campo de Fe & Esperanza residents. Her faith, knowledge of scripture and testimony to God's healing power encourage many. She prays faithfully for those she meets and rejoices to see them overcome obstacles. She is starting a Good News Club. Greda Valencia has joined Team TJ as dentist. She recently checked the teeth of 35 children & 5 parents at Carretas, finding 30 had serious dental needs. **We're looking for donors to help these kids get their teeth fixed.**

Esperanza Thanks to a small Korean church in LA, Esperanza Women's Rehab now has a propane generator which will provide several hours of electricity a day for lights and refrigeration. A chapel built by Mennonite groups, gardens and a volleyball court give a new inviting look.

Micro Enterprise: Marta recently opened a grains and produce stand using a micro loan from Team TJ. Now she can provide for her family and help sell eggs and beans wholesale to the ministries. Praise God!

Campo de Fe (CdF) has a new tile floor and other improvements, thanks to a recent grant. A new client, Jesús, loves to mop the floor from his wheelchair. Though crippled in his body, he is spiritually "walking by faith"! When old friends took him out and offered him drugs, he refused, saying he does not do that now and asked to come "home" to CdF. His family just flew him home to Chihuahua for the first visit in many years. He overflows with joy, eager to tell others about Jesus. **Pray** for Francisco, undergoing chemo for cancer, for Juan Ramon whose gangrene leg was just amputated, and for Flor, the director—a heavy load but she's faithful and cheerful.



Carretas Community Center Chela teaches children English, crafts, manners, gardening and everyday lessons about God. She has trained the children to make road repairs with stones rather than throwing them. She is teaching them to grow plants. We expect a rich harvest!

